NOT REAL ART

# Should We Put Up a Paywall?

A traffic-and-loyalty reality check before we tax our readers.
What it takes for a paywall to pay — and how
NotRealArt.com actually compares.

NotRealArt.com | For discussion with Scott | June 2026

THE QUESTION ON THE TABLE

# The Proposal

### WHAT'S BEING CONSIDERED

Install a metered subscription paywall on NotRealArt.com — let visitors read four or five articles free, then require a paid sign-up to read more. The goal: turn our audience into recurring subscription revenue.

### THE HONEST TEST

A paywall is the right tool for some publishers. The question isn't whether paywalls *work* — it's whether our traffic and our reader loyalty are anywhere near the level a paywall needs to earn more than it costs.

This deck answers that test with industry benchmarks and our own UserMaven data — before we commit engineering time and risk the reader relationship.

BEFORE WE BUILD IT — FOUR WORRIES

# What A Paywall Could Cost Us

### Alienate the audience

An art-lover community arrives to be inspired, not gated. A wall says "pay to look" — the opposite of the welcome we want.

### No meaningful revenue

At our volume and repeat rate, the math (slides ahead) lands at roughly zero dollars — after fees and platform costs, likely negative.

### Complicate the infrastructure

Accounts, billing, metering logic, churn handling, support — a whole subscription stack to maintain for a handful of dollars.

### Slow the experience & dim the brand

Meter scripts and login walls add friction and load time — and signal to artists and art lovers that we monetize attention over community.

HOW THE MODEL ACTUALLY WORKS

# A Metered Paywall Taxes Loyalty, Not Traffic

Revenue from a meter doesn't come from how many people visit. It comes from the small core who come back often enough to hit the limit — and a fraction of those who then pay. Casual one-time visitors never see the wall.

**All visitors**
Arrive from search & social

→

**Returning readers**
Come back again & again

→

**Hit the meter**
Read past the free limit

→

**Subscribe**
1–3% of those who hit it

The entire engine runs on the second box — returning readers. If almost nobody comes back, the funnel is empty before it starts.

WHAT IT TAKES — TWO PREREQUISITES

# Paywalls Need Volume AND Loyalty

PREREQUISITE 1 — VOLUME

## Hundreds of thousands of pageviews a month

Only ~0.5% of monthly unique visitors ever pay. A top performer converts ~1,000 subscribers per 1,000,000 monthly pageviews; the average is ~250. The funnel only produces real money at scale.

PREREQUISITE 2 — LOYALTY

## A large base of habitual return readers

Healthy news sites see 30–40%+ of traffic returning, and ~10% of readers drive 74% of revenue. The meter only earns from people loyal enough to come back and read past the limit.

Both are required. High volume with no loyalty, or high loyalty at tiny volume, still fails the math.

THE INDUSTRY FUNNEL

# What The Benchmarks Say A Paywall Returns

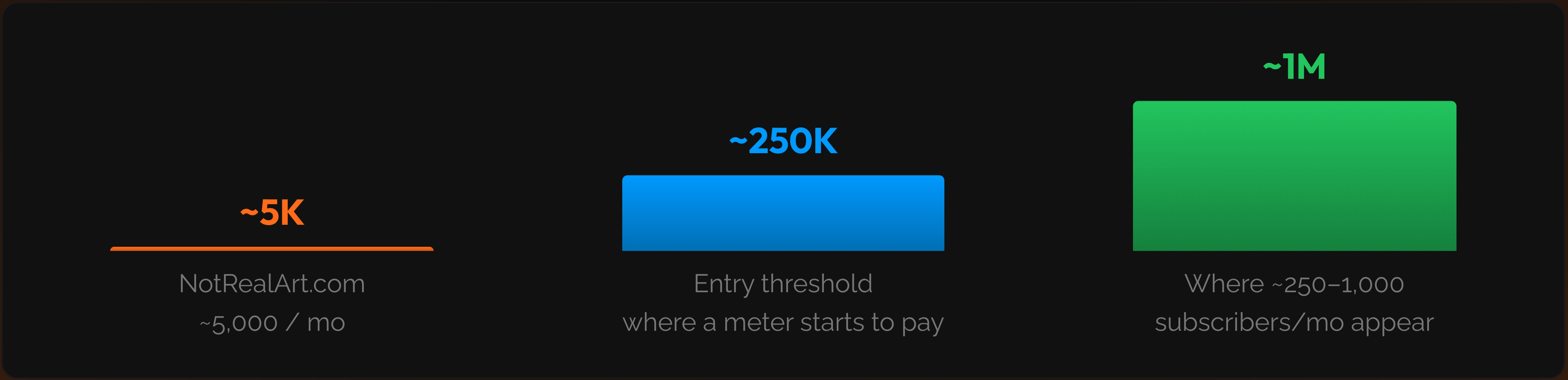
Across 85+ digital publishers, the metered funnel is brutally thin at every step. These are the numbers a healthy, loyal, high-traffic publisher hits.

| | |
|---|---|
| Monthly unique visitors who hit the paywall | **3–4%** |
| "Hit rate" — high performers vs. struggling publishers | **>6%** vs 1.8% |
| Anonymous visitor → paid subscriber (top performers) | **~2.2%** |
| Monthly unique visitors who actually pay | **~0.5%** |
| Of the *most engaged* visitors, share willing to subscribe | **5–10%** |

NOTREALART.COM — REALITY CHECK #1

# Volume: We're Two Orders Of Magnitude Short

A metered paywall starts producing meaningful revenue in the hundreds of thousands to millions of monthly pageviews. We're at roughly 5,000 visits a month.




At ~5,000 visits, our bar is barely a sliver. Even the *entry* threshold is ~50× our current traffic.

# Loyalty: Almost No One Comes Back

Our UserMaven cohort retention. A meter earns only from Period 1+ — the readers who return. Period 1 retention averages 1.1%. Roughly 1 in 90 visitors ever comes back at all — let alone often enough to read past a 5-article limit.

| | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 100% | −99% | 1.1% | → | 0.4% | 0.1% |
| Period 0<br>First visit | | Period 1<br>Return once | | Period 2 | Period 5 |

Cohort average across Nov 2025 – May 2026 (49,538 users). Source: UserMaven retention report.

Benchmark loyalty is 30–40% returning. Ours is ~1%. The audience a paywall taxes effectively does not exist here.

DO THE MATH — GENEROUS ASSUMPTIONS

# Best Case, The Meter Earns ~$0

Applying the funnel to our numbers — and being generous at every step.

| 5,000 | → | ~55 | → | ~0–1 | → | ~$0 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Monthly visits | | Return at all (1.1%) | | Read past the meter | | Subscribers / mo |

**EVEN WILDLY GENEROUS**

Apply the benchmark 0.5%-of-uniques-pay (which assumes loyalty we don't have): ~25 subs/mo × $6 = ~$150/mo ceiling. Reality, given ~1% loyalty: closer to $0–$10/mo.

**MINUS THE COSTS**

Stripe fees, a paywall platform, and ongoing dev/support time turn that ceiling net negative. We'd pay to run it.

WHO PAYWALLS ACTUALLY WORK FOR

# We're Not That Kind Of Site

| PUBLISHER | MONTHLY VOLUME | RETURN LOYALTY | WHY THE METER WORKS |
|---|---|---|---|
| The New York Times | 50–100M+ visits | Daily habit | National news people check every day; 11M+ subscribers. |
| The Atlantic | Tens of M visits | High, repeat | Deep longform readers return for must-read essays. |
| Regional daily (archetype) | 0.5–2M views | Local daily | Local news you can't get elsewhere — obituaries, schools, sports. |
| Niche trade pub (archetype) | Smaller | Must-read | Professionals expense it; the content is job-critical. |
| NotRealArt.com | ~5K visits | ~1.1% return | Episodic arts discovery — people arrive inspired, then move on. |

THE REAL DIFFERENTIATOR

# It's Not Size — It's Habit

WHERE METERS WIN

## Recurring need

Content people need on a schedule — daily news, job-critical trade info. The habit creates the return visits the meter feeds on. Missing an issue has a cost.

WHERE WE LIVE

## Serendipitous discovery

Art lovers find us through search and social, enjoy a piece, and leave inspired. That's a healthy outcome for an arts community — but it's structurally incompatible with a meter.

You can't fix a habit problem with more traffic. Even 10× the visitors, at 1% loyalty, still leaves the meter empty.

IF THE GOAL IS REVENUE — BETTER FITS

# Monetize Goodwill, Not The Fifth Click

For a low-volume, high-affinity arts community, these earn without walling readers out — and several monetize the artist side, where the willingness to pay actually lives.

### Membership / patronage

"Support us" — public-radio model. Optional, no wall, perks not gates.

### Donations / pay-what-you-want

Lower friction than subscriptions; builds trust instead of spending it.

### Sponsorship & partnerships

Galleries, art brands, supply companies reach our exact audience.

### Paid artist spotlights

Artists pay for promotion — aligned incentives, readers stay free.

### Affiliate & marketplace

Prints, books, supplies — revenue from what readers already want.

### Events & workshops

Paid community, classes, ticketed gatherings — depth over toll-gates.

# The Recommendation

Don't build a paywall now. At ~5,000 visits and ~1% return loyalty, a meter earns ~$0 while adding cost, friction, and a "pay to look" signal to a community that comes to be inspired.

**NOW**

Pursue no-wall revenue: membership, sponsorship, and paid artist spotlights. Keep the reading experience open and fast.

**REVISIT ONLY WHEN**

Traffic clears ~100K/mo AND returning-visitor share clears ~20–30% with a measurable super-user core.

# Sources & References

Evidence behind the claims in this deck

~0.5% of monthly uniques pay; ~3–4% hit the wall; ~250–1,000 subs per 1M pageviews — Nieman Lab metered-paywall data (2014), via WebPublisherPro.

Anon→subscriber ~2.2% (top); 1–3% typical; registered→sub ~19% — Piano / Audiencers Subscription & Conversion Funnel Benchmarks.

Meter-stop-rate target 5–7%; hit rate >6% vs 1.8% struggling — Poool / The Audiencers.

5–10% of most-engaged willing to subscribe — Admiral; Quintype.

~10% of readers drive ~74% of revenue (super-users) — Bounteous, 2019.

Pure metering fell 35% (2017) → 9% (2023) of publishers — WAN-IFRA / Poool.

Only 20% of Americans pay for any online news; growth plateaued — Reuters Institute Digital News Report 2025.

Donation/membership fits small niche audiences better than a wall — Elegant Themes; Donorbox.

NotRealArt.com: ~5,000 visits/mo; Period-1 retention ~1.1% (49,538 users, Nov 2025–May 2026) — UserMaven retention report, retrieved 2026-06-01.

Full URLs, quotes, and retrieval dates for every claim: `research/sources.md` in the idea folder.